

In the spotlight: (Facing page) At the heart of this event lies the idea of giving a platform for lesser-known sports and athletes, such as the bronze-winning women's sepak takraw team of Nagaland. KIBG 2026

"Only once a year do we play the Khelo India Beach Games. After this, there is nothing for us," he said. "We have so many beaches and talented players in India, and if investment was made in beach soccer, our generation could definitely play in the World Cup."

Organisational arrangements

Organisers were able to draw on lessons from the 2025 edition, with a clear emphasis on delivering a smoother, more athlete-centric experience.

That focus carries added weight in the context of India's wider sporting ambitions, with the 2030 Commonwealth Games slated for Ahmedabad — a short distance from Diu — and a long-stated intent to bid for the 2036 Olympics.

"Last year we faced a few challenges in logistics, accommodation, and transportation, which we have looked to address this year. Our main challenge is ensuring that when athletes from across India come to Diu, they face no difficulties and have a smooth experience," said Arun Gupta, Khelo India Beach Games Director-cum-Joint Secretary (Youth Affairs & Sports), Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu.

"The other challenge is ensuring that the sporting venue is ready for the technical conduct of the Games, with no deficiencies on that front," he added.

By most accounts, the issues faced in the previous edition were addressed, with athletes reporting a largely seamless experience. This extended to the conduct of the events themselves, with competitions running on schedule and equipment in place to ensure uninterrupted play.

Local crowds make their voices heard

A walk through Diu left little doubt



that the Khelo India Beach Games were in progress. Large hoardings announced the event across the town, complemented by neon installations representing each of the eight sports — a clear attempt to draw in the local community.

Attendance varied across the six days, but the latter stages drew strong crowds. Tug of war and beach soccer, in particular, proved popular, with teams from Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, as well as Gujarat, enjoying vocal home support.

"It's been a privilege to perform in both years (2025 and 2026). Being from Daman and Diu, it's a privilege to represent my state on such a big platform," said Princess Thomas, who won two medals in pencak silat.

"It's really important to perform well and gain recognition at the national level of the Khelo India Beach Games for our home state. This is our hometown, and we give the Games the utmost importance," she added.

The host contingent finished with nine medals, all in pencak silat, giving the local crowd plenty to celebrate. Thomas claimed gold in the women's tunggal category, while Prasanna Bendre topped the podium in the men's tanding 55kg category — accounting for the two gold medals in the haul.

The road forward

The focus now turns to what comes next. For many athletes at the Khelo

Way of water: Champion Karnataka ended its campaign with 11 medals, driven by a dominant showing in open water swimming. KIBG 2026

India Beach Games, the immediate answer lies in international competition. The 2026 calendar is a busy one for beach sports, with the Asian Beach Games scheduled in Sanya, China, from April 22, followed by the Asian Games in Nagoya, Japan, from September 19, where beach volleyball and sepak takraw will feature.

Beyond that, however, uncertainty remains. Between editions of the Beach Games, many athletes continue to face fragile financial security and limited competitive opportunities. Building an ecosystem that allows athletes to sustain their careers — rather than peak for isolated events — remains a pressing challenge in the lead-up to the 2027 edition.

As for the Games themselves, Gupta confirmed that the tournament is likely to remain in Diu next year, with discussions also underway to include additional sports. Should that materialise, expectations will shift once again, testing how effectively India can translate intent into durable sporting infrastructure and long-term pathways for athletes.

The writer was at the event on invitation from the Sports Authority of India.